

GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT · VERSION 1.0 · FINAL DRAFT

Ascendant Impact

Supersedes v0.4 on approval · drafted 17 August 2026 · **15 days to ship**

ENGINE Unreal 5.8 · PC	MODE 1v1 vs authored AI	SESSION 3-5 minutes
SHIP DATE 1 Sept 2026	UNAPPROVED VALUES 35 proposed	MILESTONE M1 / M2 partial

How to read this, and what authority it carries

THIS IS A DRAFT, NOT YET THE SOURCE OF TRUTH

Until it is approved and re-issued as the revised PDF, `Ascendant_Impact_Assignment_02_Revised_GDD_Anthony.pdf` (v0.4) remains the source of truth and `gdd/` remains its mechanical export. Nothing here has been written back into `gdd/`, which is generated and never hand-edited.

What v1.0 adds to v0.4. v0.4 described a game. v1.0 describes the same game, plus: what has actually been built since 24 July, every value that has been researched or settled since, the honest gap between the two, and the plan that gets a complete fought duel onto disk by 1 September.

Nothing in v0.4's authored design has been reversed. Scope lock, pillars, the core loop, the meter, the double gate, the six-state rival, the four-attack set, the no-runtime-AI rule, and the milestone order all stand exactly as written.

Status key — every value carries one

TAG	MEANING
<code>LOCKED</code>	Authored in GDD v0.4. Not a tuning value; changing it changes what the game is.
<code>APPROVED</code>	Decided by the designer of record since v0.4 and recorded in <code>design/decisions.md</code> . Binding.
<code>PROPOSED</code>	Researched, with a recommendation on disk, and not decided . No agent, document, or build may treat it as canon.
<code>OPEN</code>	No answer yet. Named here so it is visible rather than silently filled.
<code>BUILT</code>	Exists and runs in the Unreal project today, with PIE evidence.

THE RULE THIS DOCUMENT KEEPS

A **proposed** number is not a number. It may be typed into a document, never into a Blueprint default. The designer of record owns every one of them.

Executive summary

Choose an Ascendant operative. Survive one complete duel. Earn the spectacle.

The player selects **Agent Echo** or **Agent Nova** and enters the **Shattered Ring** to fight **Crimson Vanguard / Project Valor-7** in one complete third-person duel. Combat is primarily real time: movement, attacks, dodges, perfect dodges, and counters build Ascension energy and earn brief anime-inspired cinematic bursts, culminating in one recoverable **Final Clash**. **LOCKED**

Scope lock — reaffirmed without change. One player, one authored AI opponent, one official arena, one shared player-combat framework, four authored rival attacks, one complete duel with win and loss outcomes.

Design pillars **LOCKED**

PILLAR	PLAYER-FACING MEANING
1 • Skill Creates Spectacle	Readable timing and deliberate decisions earn the strongest visual rewards.
2 • Cinematic Rhythm	Brief camera, hit-stop, impact-frame, and VFX bursts punctuate combat without replacing it.
3 • Operative Identity vs. Vanguard Force	Echo emphasizes precision and controlled timing; Nova emphasizes speed and aggressive momentum; Crimson Vanguard embodies armor, pressure, and overwhelming force.

Character motivation. Echo and Nova are Ascendant operatives entering the Shattered Ring to survive a live combat evaluation against Project Valor-7, an armored Vanguard unit designed to push enhanced fighters beyond their operational limits.

What changed in the world since v0.4

v0.4 was written before a line of the game existed. Since then a playable graybox duel exists in Unreal — movement, a duel camera, a telegraphed rival strike the player can whiff or interrupt, damage, a HUD, a knockout, and a jump-over side-switch — and a full design-research pass has produced a recommended value for nearly every blank the GDD deliberately left. **§05 states what is in the build. §12 states what is still unapproved. §10 is the plan that closes the distance.**

Real-time combat and the selectable roster

The duel is an action-combat game with short earned timing prompts, not a sequence of QTE scenes.

Control model. LOCKED Movement, lock-on, light attacks, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health, spacing, and opponent reads occur in real time. Impact Windows and the Final Clash are brief authored overlays triggered by gameplay performance. They never replace the main combat loop, never auto-play an entire fight, and always return control to the player.

Core loop. 1 READ the rival's telegraph → 2 RESPOND attack, dodge, or counter → 3 BUILD Ascension energy → 4 IMPACT choose the timing input → 5 ESCALATE adapt to Phase 2 → 6 CLASH attempt the Final Clash.

SELECTABLE ROSTER · LOCKED		
FIGHTER	COMBAT IDENTITY	PROTOTYPE EXPRESSION
Agent Echo 6'0" / 183 CM	Lean precision striker	Controlled spacing, deliberate movement, perfect-dodge timing, counters, restrained orange accents
Agent Nova 5'8" / 173 CM	Agile pressure striker	Faster visual rhythm, lateral movement, aggressive momentum, preserved costume palette, cyan-white combat energy

Shared player-kit scope rule. Echo and Nova share the same prototype framework: movement, lock-on, light attack sequence, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health, Ascension Meter, Impact Windows, and Final Clash. Their differences are animation presentation, stance personality, VFX language, timing flavor, and introduction. Unique move sets, separate balance systems, and extensive character-specific cinematics are deferred until the base duel is stable.

Player combat kit — the tuning layer

Every row below fills a blank v0.4 deliberately left open. **All proposed.** They are the first batch that must be signed, because M1 cannot be signed off without them.

SYSTEM	RECOMMENDED	STATUS	HOME
Player max health, both fighters	100	Q1	DA_TuningGlobals
Light combo sections	3 · ≈ 1.0 s total	Q5	AM_Player_LightCombo
Light hit / finisher damage	5 / 10 · total 20	Q4	combo notify data
Combo input buffer	0.25 s (75% of a section)	Q28	AM_Player_LightCombo
Dodge invulnerability	0.28 s · [0.03, 0.31]	Q6	ANS_IFrame

SYSTEM	RECOMMENDED	STATUS	HOME
Perfect-dodge window	0.12 s · [0.03, 0.15]	Q7 BLOCKING	ANS_PerfectDodge
Counter whiff lockout	0.55 s	Q8	AM_Player_CounterWhiff
Walk / strafe / backpedal	600 / 420 / 360 uu/s	Q15	DA_FighterProfile
Dodge distance	400 cm · Motion Warping	Q16	DA_FighterProfile
Montage play rate (cosmetic)	1.000 / 1.000	Q14	DA_FighterProfile
Lock-on acquire / break / interp / socket	3000 / 3300 cm · 6.0 · 140 cm @ -8°	Q11	BP_LockOnComponent

THREE STRUCTURAL FINDINGS THAT TRAVEL WITH THOSE NUMBERS

- 1. **Q14 must be renamed** `CosmeticMontagePlayRate` and restricted to a four-montage allowlist carrying no gameplay notify states, routed through one library node that `ensure()` s the montage is notify-free. Otherwise per-fighter play rate silently scales the i-frame and perfect-dodge windows into per-fighter difficulty. The guard must be **scoped to the player kit** — the rival's telegraph and recover scaling legitimately uses play rate.
- 2. **Q16 uses Motion Warping deliberately.** Warping changes displacement without touching the montage timeline Q6 and Q7 sit on. Play rate would move both.
- 3. **ANS_ActiveHit and ANS_ComboLink overlap on the same section and must not be merged.** `bComboQueued` clears on next-section begin and on any montage interruption. A successful counter must never play `AM_Player_CounterWhiff`.

KNOWN WEAKNESS, STATED PLAINLY

Q8 has no prior-art support — no shipped game publishes whiffed-parry recovery frames — and is derived purely from the GDD's own ranges. Its anti-spam intent also **fails against slow Phase 1 telegraphs (0.75–0.95 s)**; closing that gap needs ~0.95 s of lockout, which is unplayable. Accepted as a beginner crutch that dies at Phase 2 — and it forces a rule on §04: **do not author all four attacks near 0.95 s.**

Impact Windows LOCKED

A qualifying real-time event — a perfect dodge, a counter, or an approved combo milestone — can open one short contextual timing prompt. Success extends the exchange into a **1–3 second** choreographed burst. Failure does not auto-correct the input; the game returns immediately to normal combat.

WINDOW	TRIGGER	RESPONSE TIME	FAILURE RESULT
First Impact Window	First successful perfect dodge or counter	0.75 s LOCKED	No extension; return to combat with no extra punishment
Standard Impact Window	Approved skill event after cooldown	0.35–0.50 s LOCKED	No extension; return to combat
Cooldown between windows	Clocked on window <i>close</i>	7.0 s Q26	First window exempt

Onboarding rule. The first Impact Window is intentionally wider, but it still requires the player's input and must be earned through a successful real-time defensive action. The game does not press the input for the player and does not convert a miss into success. **The first-window cooldown exemption is therefore not optional** — applying the cooldown to the first window would break this rule.

Ascension Meter, Final Clash, encounter flow

The Ascension Meter is a visible **0–100** resource earned only through active combat decisions. It does not fill from waiting or elapsed time. LOCKED

PLAYER EVENT	METER GAIN	DESIGN INTENT
Light-combo finisher	+5	Small reward for sustained offense
Perfect dodge	+12	Reward a clean defensive read
Successful counter	+15	Reward converting the opening
Impact Window success	+20	Reward execution during an earned cinematic beat
Taking damage / waiting	+0	Prevent passive progress

Meter decay: none. Q9 `MeterDecayRate` should not exist as a variable at all — no Tick, no timer, no float. Constraint **C1** of the approved Q22 requires it, and it is shown falsifiably: a decay of just **0.76 pts/s** zeroes a struggling player's income and makes the game unwinnable while the loss condition stays live.

WHAT THE METER ACTUALLY IS — CORRECTED

No cooldown value in 3–8 s can make the meter a genuine *second race* against the health gate. With Impact Windows disabled entirely, twenty finishers still fill the meter in ~84 s against a health gate at ~173 s, and every lever to halve that is closed: gains are GDD-fixed, C1 forbids decay, the 0–100 ceiling is GDD-fixed. **The meter is an anti-passivity floor, not a race.** Q26 = 7 s still cuts the +20 row's dominance from a ~2.25× speedup to ~1.67×.

Final Clash unlock LOCKED

The Final Clash becomes available only when **both** conditions are true:
Ascension Meter full at **100** and Crimson Vanguard's health at or below **25%**.
If one condition is met first, the Clash stays locked until the other is met.
Once eligible, the player initiates it with a contextual input during neutral or after a successful counter.

APPROVED 2026-08-02 — Q22 — THE 1 HP FLOOR IS PERMANENT

`MinHealthFloor = 1` on the rival's health component from `BeginPlay`, lowered to `0` only by `ClashSuccess()` immediately before it applies lethal damage. **The Final Clash is the only way to win the duel.** Chip damage can pin Crimson Vanguard at 1 HP forever; it can never kill him.

The GDD's encounter-flow table lists exactly one win condition. The other reading requires *adding* a win condition the GDD never writes down; this one only widens the scope of a floor the GDD does state. It makes the double gate meaningful and makes the meter — and therefore skill — the only route to the ending.

THREE CONSTRAINTS THAT FOLLOW FROM Q22 AND BIND EVERYTHING BELOW IT

CONSTRAINT	REQUIREMENT	STATE
C1	Q9 must resolve to <i>no meter decay</i> , or the tail becomes a dead end	SATISFIED BY Q9
C2	The HUD must show which gate is still locked once the health bar visibly pins	MANDATORY, UNBUILT
C3	Q2 tuned so $\leq 25\%$ health and meter 100 arrive close together	NOT SATISFIED

FINAL CLASH RESOLUTION · LOCKED

OUTCOME	RULE	RETURN STATE
Success	Complete both timing beats; the finishing sequence defeats Crimson Vanguard and ends the duel	Win screen
Failure	Separate both fighters; preserve current health with the rival held at a 1 HP floor ; reduce meter to 50 ; apply a 3-second re-trigger cooldown	Return to Neutral; rebuild and try again

Failed-Clash recovery. A failed Final Clash does not restart the duel, kill the player automatically, or leave either fighter in a cinematic state. It creates a meaningful meter setback, restores valid combat states, and preserves a recoverable path to victory.

FINAL CLASH EXECUTION LAYER · ALL PROPOSED

PARAMETER	RECOMMENDED	STATUS
Beat-1 lead-in after initiation	<code>1.2 s (band 1.0–1.3) = CounterRecoveryLength + 0.6</code>	Q19
Both beat windows	<code>0.50 s, identical</code>	Q20
Separation on failure	<code>1200 cm along the long axis (band 1100–1300)</code>	Q21
Clash input	<code>Reuse IA_Impact, routed by bClashBeatOpen</code>	Q17
Retry timer	<code>None – the variable should not exist</code>	Q23

- **Q19 corrects a defect in the design brief's own range.** The brief offered 0.5–1.5 s; **1.5 s is unsafe** — the earliest legal Phase 2 strike after a counter is 1.30 s, so 1.5 s would let the player Clash out of an incoming hit.
- **Q20 argues against making beat 2 tighter.** Under Q22 that makes the more expensive failure the more likely one. *Asura's Wrath* is the named failure mode; *Final Fantasy XVI*'s unfailable clash is rejected by name against the no-auto-success rule.
- **Q21 implementation:** `Teleport = true`, not sweep; `ProjectPointToNavigation` first; applied under the camera cut.

Retry-loop verdict: acceptable, with margin — but the penalty is regressive. One retry costs ≈ 19 s for a strong player and ≈ 71 s for a struggling one. The 3-second cooldown is never binding; the fastest possible rebuild is 13.8 s. A competent player can fail four times and still finish inside 5:00, and the tail cannot run away because the loss condition bounds it.

THE QUESTION THIS DOCUMENT MOST WANTS ANSWERED

The practical meaning of Q22 plus Q20 is that a player who cannot execute the two beats **loses the duel rather than grinding it out**. That is defensible — it is *Sekiro*'s position — but it makes “*I fought well for four minutes and lost to two timing beats*” a reachable outcome. If that is not the intended experience, the lever is Q20's window, not the Q22 floor.

ENCOUNTER FLOW · LOCKED		
BEAT	RULE	PLAYER EXPERIENCE
Opening	Selection, abbreviated entrance, then immediate control	Establish identity and stakes without delaying play
Phase 1	Readable armored pressure; onboarding Impact Window available	Learn Crimson Vanguard's rhythm
Phase 2	Begins at 50% rival health; same attacks, stronger pressure	Apply learned reads under stress
Climax	Meter 100 + rival health $\leq 25\%$	Player chooses the Final Clash attempt
Win / Loss	Final Clash success / selected fighter health reaches zero	Complete duel loop

TWO ECONOMY TENSIONS CARRIED INTO PLAYTEST

1. **Post-failed-Clash rebuild leaves $\sim 15\text{--}35$ s of genuinely inert damage** — the player is hitting a rival pinned at 1 HP while rebuilding meter. This is what makes **C2's HUD gate indicator mandatory**.
2. **The two-hit-and-bail player** never finishes a string, earns no meter, and can reach a pinned rival with an empty bar. No tuning value closes this; it is handed to the HUD, the onboarding window, and the combo buffer.

Crimson Vanguard — authored rival AI

Runtime AI boundary. LOCKED Crimson Vanguard is controlled by authored Unreal gameplay AI — a compact state machine or Behavior Tree.

The packaged duel makes no runtime LLM calls, does not learn from the player, and does not generate attacks or choreography dynamically.

Idle / Reposition → Select Attack → Telegraph → Active Attack → Recover → Return to Neutral

STATE FLOW · LOCKED SHAPE, LOCKED RANGES			
STATE	PURPOSE	PHASE 1	PHASE 2
Idle / Reposition	Face the selected fighter and maintain armored pressure	0.60–1.20 s	0.35–0.80 s
Select Attack	Choose one of four authored attacks by range and cooldown	0.10–0.20 s	0.10–0.20 s
Telegraph	Committed pose, warning lights, sound, readable direction	0.55–0.95 s	0.40–0.75 s
Active Attack	Authored movement, gauntlet force, hitbox, reach, propulsion	0.18–0.45 s	0.18–0.45 s
Recover	Expose a deliberate punish opening after the committed strike	0.45–0.90 s	0.35–0.75 s
Return to Neutral	Clear attack flags and restore valid locomotion	0.10–0.20 s	0.10–0.20 s

The GDD publishes these ranges per state, not per attack. Any chosen value must fall inside its published range, and collapsing a range to a single number on an agent's own authority is itself a violation.

FOUR-ATTACK COURSE SET · LOCKED		
ATTACK	RANGE / PURPOSE	READABILITY REQUIREMENT
A	Close-range committed gauntlet force	Distinct wind-up and punishable recovery
B	Committed forward-pressure sequence	Visible first beat and stable tracking limit
C	Armored reach and space control	Clear body direction and visible active range
D	Short propulsion-assisted approach	Thruster cue before movement; no hidden full-arena snap

Working names, and their exact status. *Fault Line* (A), *Advance Line* (B), *Bulwark Reach* (C), *Thruster Snap* (D) were generated by the content pipeline and carried into the attack CSV. They are **proposed placeholder labels, not canon**. Only the designer may promote them.

Per-attack tuning — 26 values Q25

Range compliance: 26 / 26 in range. 0 out of range. 0 GDD ranges altered or collapsed. Independently recomputed and confirmed by the cross-consistency inspection.

ATTACK	TELEGRAPH P1	TELEGRAPH P2	ACTIVE (BOTH)	RECOVER P1	RECOVER P2
A	0.70	0.55	0.22	0.85	0.68
B	0.60	0.48	0.36	0.70	0.56
C	0.80	0.62	0.30	0.60	0.48
D	0.90	0.70	0.45 AT MAX	0.55	0.44

Duel-level: Reposition **0.90 / 0.55**, Select Attack **0.15 / 0.15**, Return to Neutral **0.15 / 0.15**. Telegraph tracks range (close = short); Recover tracks commitment inversely — D is shortest because D exists to set up A.

PARAMETER	PHASE 1	PHASE 2	STATUS
Engagement bands, centre-to-centre	A 0–260 · B 90–520 · C 240–420 · D 400–840 cm	identical	Q10
Attack cooldowns	3.0 / 3.5 / 3.6 / 3.8 s	2.5 / 2.6 / 2.7 / 2.8 s	Q12
Damage, % of player max HP	A 32 · B 25 · C 27 · D 18	identical	Q3
Attack D travel	600 cm, finishing 240 cm from the target	identical	Q13
Rival max health	1200 (band 1100–1400)	–	Q2
Telegraph notify offset	MontageLength / EffectivePlayRate + 0.35	–	Q18
Recover-window damage multiplier	1.0 – no bonus	–	Q27
Rival scale	208 cm	–	ITEM 28
Rival MaxWalkSpeed	–	–	OPEN · SERIOUS

FOUR FINDINGS THE IMPLEMENTATION MUST NOT MISS

1. **ActiveSeconds** must never gain a per-phase field. Scaling D's 0.45 s by the ~0.78 Phase 2 ratio makes 600 cm cross at **1714 cm/s** and breaks the GDD's own no-snap rule. It belongs on the row, outside both phase structs. D's Active sits on the published maximum with zero upward headroom — the validator must be `Min <= Value <= Max`.
2. **Attack B's first-to-last hit notify must span ≤ 0.26 s**, or the 0.28 s i-frame window cannot cover the sequence and **B becomes unavoidable**.
3. **Attack B's table row is *total* attack damage, split across notifies**. Authored as multiple hit windows each reading 25, B deals 50–75% of player health in one attack and the damage budget is void. This is the most likely way the table silently produces a broken fight.
4. **Attack A's Phase 1 cycle is 2.97 s against a 3.0 s cooldown — 0.03 s of slack**. At 0–90 cm, where A is the only legal attack, that is A every ~3.0 s at 32 damage: **10.7 dmg/s against 100 HP**. Every legal choice of the six state values lands the cycle in 2.8–3.2 s, so it cannot be fixed from inside the timings. **Q12, Q25 and Q3 need one joint tuning session**.

Band coverage is proved, not assumed: contiguous over [0, 840] cm with 80 cm and 120 cm handoff overlaps, depth ≥ 2 across the whole 100–520 cm fight zone. The single zero-coverage region (840–2884 cm) and the single depth-1 region (520–840 cm) are **both closed by a required advance rule** rather than by accident — which is the reposition-loop deadlock the design brief warned about, closed deliberately. Starvation checks pass in both phases at the fastest legal cycle, tightest slack **+0.16 s**.

Phase 2 escalation. **LOCKED** Phase 2 begins when Crimson Vanguard reaches 50% health. The change is committed on **Return to Neutral**, then signaled once with stronger thruster output, warning lights, sound, and armor-energy presentation. It uses **the same four authored attacks — no transformation rig and no second move set**. Only pressure parameters and presentation change.

Build state and technical milestones

Validate the complete gameplay contract before expanding presentation.

MILESTONES · LOCKED ORDER, WITH TODAY'S HONEST STATE		
MILESTONE	REQUIRED PROOF	STATE · 17 AUG
M1 Combat gray box	Movement, lock-on, light sequence, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health	~40% BUILT
M2 Rival state loop	All six AI states and one attack complete without deadlock	REDUCED FORM
M3 Impact handoff	Earned prompt, success/failure branches, restored control	DESIGN COMPLETE, UNBUILT
M4 Complete duel	Meter, Phase 2, Final Clash, failure recovery, win/loss	DESIGN COMPLETE, UNBUILT
M5 Presentation pass	Character treatment, arena reaction, camera, VFX, sound	CORRECTLY GATED BEHIND M4

What is in the Unreal project today BUILT

Every item below has PIE evidence in the project blackboard, compiles clean with warnings_as_errors=true , and logs zero Blueprint runtime errors.

BUILT	DETAIL
Playable duel graybox	Lvl_DuelGraybox — flat contained arena, both fighters grounded, perimeter geometry outside combat bounds
Duel camera rig	Fixed arena-side 2.5D framing, constant yaw, midpoint tracking, mutual look-at facing with an interp guard; cannot flip when fighters swap sides
Player movement + jump	Screen-space input; JumpZVelocity 820 / GravityScale 1.9 / AirControl 0.35 — apex ≈180 cm, airtime ≈0.9 s
Jump-over & dynamic side switching	Side ownership computed from positions with a deadzone; mutual move-ignore during the crossing; symmetric restore; no state leak on knockout
Player attack → damage	Facing-driven overlap, 10 damage per hit, exactly one event per swing
Vanguard movement AI	Preferred-range band with hysteresis (advance / hold / retreat), depth wander, arena clamp, side-aware constraint solver
One telegraphed Vanguard strike	1.1 s wind-up, "!" telegraph, cooldowns 2.5–4.0 s, interruptible any time before the impact check, 55 cm depth-dodge tolerance
Duel HUD	Mirrored player / Vanguard health bars driven by authoritative health, 0.05 s timer update, interpolated settle
Knockout	Health floor at 0, ragdoll, one-shot, attacks blocked after KO, full reset on restart — both fighters

What is not in the build yet

Player kit: the light-combo montage and its sections, the dodge, the perfect-dodge window, the counter, lock-on. The current punch is a single overlap, not the 3-section combo. **Rival:** the six named states as an explicit machine, attack selection by range band, attacks A–D as data rows, Phase 2. **Systems:** the Ascension Meter, the HUD gate indicator, Impact Windows and the whole real-time-to-cinematic handoff, the Final Clash and its two beats, failed-Clash recovery, win and loss end states, character selection.

Four divergences that must be reconciled before M2 signs off

1 · ARCHITECTURE — DESIGN LINE VS. BUILT LINE

The design line targets `BP_CrimsonVanguard` driven by a Behavior Tree with six task nodes reading a DataTable. The built line has a timer-driven attack driver plus a duel mover that already implements **Telegraph** → **Active** → **Recover** → **cooldown** and covers **Idle / Reposition**, with **Select Attack** absent only because there is one attack.

Recommendation, and it is the designer's call: keep the built driver and complete it into the six states rather than rebuilding on a Behavior Tree. The state contract is what the GDD locks; the node graph that satisfies it is not. Rebuilding costs days the calendar does not have.

2 · Rival health is hardcoded to 100 in the proxy (the HUD divides by 100 to match), against a proposed 1200. Nothing is broken by this today — it is a graybox default — but it must move to `DA_TuningGlobals` before any damage tuning means anything.

3 · The arena footprint does not match the proposed one. The built combat axis is ± 650 cm; the proposal is 2400×1600 cm. Attack D's 600 cm travel and the Clash's 1200 cm separation both assume the larger floor. Camera framing is coupled to those bounds — `DistancePerSeparation` and `MaxCameraDistance` retune in the same pass.

4 · THE ATTACK DATATABLE ROUTE IS PAUSED IN THE ENGINE PROJECT

Pending a human un-pause. The user-defined struct cannot be created through the MCP at all — it is a manual editor step. **M2 cannot start until that pause is lifted and the struct is made by hand.** When it resumes, row data imports verbatim from the approved CSV, and nothing marked OPEN in the source audit may be invented.

Implementation safeguards LOCKED

- Authored state-machine or Behavior Tree logic with **visible debug state names** and deterministic recovery paths.
- **Separate gameplay timing from cinematic presentation** so hit-stop, camera, and VFX can be disabled during diagnosis.
- **Restore input, collision, locomotion, lock-on, and AI state explicitly** after every Impact Window and Final Clash branch.
- Validate both avatars against the same collision, targeting, reach, and boundary tests.
- **Treat all timing ranges, meter values, and health thresholds as provisional** until validated through playtesting and finalized by the designer.

The cinematic restore contract V1-V5 APPROVED NOT APPLIED

Five corrections to the cinematic handoff were approved as engineering on 2 August. They clear the one hard check the cinematic inspection failed, and **M3 does not sign off until they are applied.**

CORRECTION	WHAT IT DOES
V1	A second park key alongside the Clash flag, released only in <code>RestoreCombatState()</code> . Nothing is suspended while a window is merely open — combat continues under the prompt. Mandatory, not a preference: a burst can begin mid-Telegraph.
V2	View target returned to the possessed player as an unconditional restore step, called directly on the <code>PlayerController</code> , never through the presentation subsystem.
V3	All hit-window state moved off the notify object onto the combat components behind an interface, keyed by a monotonic <code>WindowID</code> ; orphan-scoped force-close from restore and tick. Retires the notify-end dependency — <code>Received Notify End</code> is documented as unreliable under montage interruption.
V4	Per-branch montage-cleanup ledger; a single terminal <code>bDuelOver</code> rule resolves death during any overlay.
V5	Blind tag clear replaced with a resync over a closed seven-tag set, reading V3's window registry.

A LATENT BUG THESE CORRECTIONS PREVENT

Restore also runs on the Impact **failure** branch, where nothing was suspended — so a blind clear of the invulnerable and perfect-window tags **strips a player's i-frames mid-dodge** if a window expires during that dodge. Adding the dodging tag to the blind clear list would have widened the bug rather than fixing it.

AI-assisted development architecture

Human approval gate. LOCKED Generative tools may support ideation, reference exploration, documentation, and offline draft assets. **No generated combat behavior, character asset, animation, VFX, sound, or text enters the build without human review, technical validation, rights review, and explicit approval.**

AREA	ALLOWED SUPPORT	COURSE-BUILD BOUNDARY
Design	Brainstorming, comparison, tuning hypotheses, documentation drafts	Designer approves all rules and numbers
Visual development	Reference exploration and look-direction drafts	Human-selected assets only; no automatic final import
Code support	Offline implementation suggestions and debugging assistance	Reviewed source and authored Unreal runtime logic
Runtime opponent	None	Deterministic authored AI; no runtime LLM
Playable fighters	None at runtime	Player input controls Echo or Nova; no agent automation

What was actually built under this architecture

All of it is **offline authoring tooling that lives outside the game's scope lock**. None of it ships in the packaged build, and none of it makes a runtime call.

TOOL	WHAT IT DOES	STATE
The agent crew (6 agents)	designer → developer → inspector, plus framework evaluator, integration architect, cinematic inspector. Hook-gated in Python: an agent cannot spawn until its upstream leave-off says complete	6 artifacts on disk
The goal planner	Differs what the GDD says the game is against what is recorded as decided, ranks the remainder by the lowest build step each item blocks, and stops when the top item is a design question	built
The content pipeline	RAG over a knowledge base that is the extracted GDD, with a critic agent enforcing seven consistency rules — telegraph packs, Impact beat packs, arena reactions, animation briefs, VFX/audio cue sheets, QA packs	175 tests pass
The arena pipeline	Generate → deterministic validate (R1–R8) → evaluate on four weighted criteria → refine one field at a time → three-attempt circuit breaker → Unreal materializer. Refuses and exits rather than inventing a missing requirement	77 tests pass
The GER pipeline	Generates the seventeen-column attack rows, gated so a fifth attack, a new Phase 2 move, or an invented value for an OPEN field cannot pass	evidence committed
The style-guide agent	Governs player-facing combat copy — Impact prompts, meter feedback, the Phase 2 callout, the Clash unlock, the failed-Clash recovery line, the loss screen — scored, refined, and graded by a real model	139 pass, 2 skipped

The rule that makes this safe is enforced, not promised. Every generated value carries a source and a status; pipelines exit with a request for human review rather than filling a blank. A value left **OPEN is a pass**, not a gap to fill.

A DRAFTING RULE THAT BELONGS IN THE GDD

Player-facing copy prints **no numbers**, because every meter value is provisional. The Final Clash unlock banner therefore announces readiness rather than teaching the gate, and **must never present a full meter alone as the unlock**.

Optional coursework still available — a narrative engine and an adversarial QA agent — is tooling, not game scope. Neither is on the critical path to 1 September, and neither may add a game feature.

Character readability, scale, opening flow

Three distinct combat identities remain legible inside one shared design family.

CATEGORY	AGENT ECHO	AGENT NOVA	CRIMSON VANGUARD
Combat identity	Precision and controlled timing	Speed and aggressive momentum	Armor, pressure, overwhelming force
Movement	Deliberate spacing and counters	Fast lateral rhythm, forward intent	Committed advances, short propulsion
Silhouette	Lean, upright technical striker	Compact, agile layered profile	Substantially broader armored mass
Material family	Matte black and charcoal technical suit	Black, charcoal, orange, light-gray helmet cap	Red armor over black structure
Energy / VFX	Controlled orange accents	Cyan-white combat energy	Red-orange systems and warning lights
Gameplay role	Selectable player avatar	Selectable player avatar	Sole authored AI rival
Readability target	Exact timing, clear counter intent	Momentum without visual noise	Threatening reach with obvious tells

Character scale. Nova 5'8" / 173 cm, Echo 6'0" / 183 cm, Crimson Vanguard 6'10" / 208 cm ITEM 28. Uniform scale only; the capsule scales with the mesh. **The height difference must not create unfair hidden reach or collision behavior**, and reach is re-validated after any scale change. **Rival width remains unspecified** — do not derive a capsule radius from "roughly twice the shoulder width."

PROXY CAST FOR PHASE 1		
ROLE	PROXY	STATUS
Agent Echo	Manny (UE mannequin)	BUILT
Agent Nova	Quinn	DEFERRED UNTIL ECHO PROVES THE PIPELINE
Crimson Vanguard	Scaled mannequin at 1.1 stature today; Paragon: Crunch recommended	Q30 · DECIDE-BY DATE PASSED
Shattered Ring	Gray-box floor, walls, one doorway axis	PARTIAL

Why Crunch, if it is taken: it wins on the two reference-sheet lines that matter for readability — a **fully enclosed fist with no weapon** ("the hand *is* the weapon") and **mech proportion with a small head**. Steel loses on the shield. Building on Crunch's own skeleton with Crunch's own animation cycles removes the retargeting pass from the critical path: ≈ 1.0 day cost, offset by $\approx 0.5\text{--}1.0$ day returned on attack-animation sourcing. **Swapping after the attack rows are authored costs 2.0–3.0 days and is forbidden.**

PRESENTATION DECISIONS · PROPOSED, ALL PLACED IN M5

ITEM	DECISION
Echo's faceplate ITEM 43	Visor AND light — dark visor plane plus one small indicator in the helmet position Nova's already occupies. No gameplay-state modulation. Under reverse third-person framing the face is off-camera for the entire duel, so it is not a viable readability channel and must not be made one.
Energy lines ITEM 44	Emissive and Ascension-responsive for both fighters — one scalar on the shared master material, per-fighter masks, stepped at 50 and 100 , intensity only, no hue change. Never the only channel; the HUD stays authoritative.
Fighter unit line ITEM 45	"SFN" cannot be established and is not established. Ship the badge as art; expose the field blank.
Rival in-combat UI label Q29	Recommend VALOR-7 ; ship the field blank until approved. CRIMSON VANGUARD is 16 characters against a 16-character nameplate budget with zero localization headroom.

A readability tension that is mitigated, not removed: Echo's orange sits next to the rival's red-orange warning lights. The mitigating rule — **the rival owns animated emissive, the player owns static or stepped** — makes the risk testable rather than gone.

Character selection and opening flow

Echo and Nova appear in a clean editorial selection interface; the player moves between both options; technical panels animate around the selected fighter; the interface transitions into the arena; the camera moves behind the selected fighter; Crimson Vanguard enters through the far doorway; the duel begins.

COURSE-BUILD ALLOWANCE — LOAD-BEARING FOR THE SHIP DATE

The build may use a **simplified selection screen and an abbreviated arena entrance** while preserving the same readable sequence.

Visual assets and the Version 1 arena

The established industrial Shattered Ring is locked as the official Version 1 environment. LOCKED Alternate environment explorations do not replace it.

ARENA REQUIREMENT	VERSION 1 FUNCTION
Central combat floor	Open, readable space for spacing, lock-on, dodges, counters, and Final Clash staging
Far doorway	Dedicated Crimson Vanguard entrance axis
Reverse third-person framing	Clear camera position behind the selected fighter
Side-on readability	Readable silhouettes and attack direction during lateral exchanges
Environmental reaction	Visible but controlled reaction during major impacts, without adding gameplay hazards

ARENA FOOTPRINT · PROPOSED		
PARAMETER	RECOMMENDED	STATUS
Playable floor	2400 × 1600 cm, long axis = doorway axis, four 250 cm 45° chamfers	Q24
Stored as	ArenaLongAxisCm / ArenaShortAxisCm	SO TRAVEL CANNOT DRIFT
Diagonal	≈2884 cm – beyond both lock-on distances	DERIVED
Mezzanine	Set dressing – no NavMesh, no blocking volume, railings NoCollision	ITEM 18

The five supplied reference sheets — character scale, the arena, Echo, Nova, and the Crimson Vanguard technical board — are recovered and described in the repository. **Authored GDD text outranks any image description, and nothing marked ambiguous in those descriptions may be guessed at.**

Asset sourcing and rights — the Phase 1 position

Assets cost \$0, must be licensed for a submitted course build, and still pass human approval and rights review. Where no free asset exists, the gap is named and a free fallback proposed — never a purchase assumed.

- **Branding exposure is zero** ITEM 20. The swoosh appears only on the concept sheets, on no asset in the build or the plan. Remedy is a five-minute recorded verification when the proxies are dressed, plus a one-sentence constraint on final art that does not exist yet.
- **Audio: Phase 1 ships without an audio pass** Q31, and that is said here rather than discovered. No M1–M4 gate names audio; only M5's does. **But not literally silent** — a capped **6–9 one-shot cue floor at ≈ 0.5 day**, sequenced *after* M4's gate, routed through the presentation subsystem so it stays disable-able. Source: **CC0-filtered only** — every other licence there carries an attribution obligation.
- **This has an honest cost.** The GDD names sound as a Telegraph and Phase 2 channel. Shipping the pass in M5 means that channel is absent in Phase 1, so **pose, warning lights, and emissive carry the whole readability load** — which is exactly why the capped cue floor exists.
- **Gaps with no free source:** the rival's back-vane silhouette (omit in Phase 1 — telegraph pose plus emissive carries Attack D's cue), a martial-arts strike set with the intended weight, character art matching the sheets, and a UI icon set (text and plain bars suffice).

Scope lock and the release cut line

Scope lock — **unchanged from v0.4.** LOCKED The prototype is complete when the player can select Echo or Nova, enter the official arena, fight Crimson Vanguard through both phases, earn and resolve Impact Windows, reach and retry the Final Clash, and finish with a valid win or loss.

INCLUDED

One player versus one authored AI opponent · two selectable avatars on one shared framework · one boss with six states, four attacks, and a parameter-based Phase 2 · one arena, one complete duel, complete win/loss handling · Impact Window onboarding, Ascension Meter, Final Clash unlock, failed-Clash recovery · human approval gates and no runtime LLM-controlled fighters.

DEFERRED FUTURE SCOPE

Local or online PvP · unique Echo and Nova move sets or separate balance systems · a playable Crimson Vanguard kit · multi-enemy encounters, campaign progression, additional arenas, extended gauntlets · transformations, second boss kits, additional characters, modes, weapons, or story chapters.

The release cut line NEW · NEEDS APPROVAL

Fifteen days remain. The scope lock is what the prototype *is*; the list below is the order in which parts of it get sacrificed if the calendar wins. **The first two entries cut items the scope lock names, which makes them the designer's call and nobody else's.**

CUT ORDER	WHAT IS LOST	WHAT SURVIVES
1 · Attacks C and D	Two of the four authored attacks	A and B cover 0–520 cm; the band coverage proof holds only if the advance rule is retuned
2 · Nova as a second avatar	Half of "two selectable avatars"	The selection screen still shows both; Echo is playable. Largest single day saving, largest scope concession
3 · Attack D's propulsion travel	The gap-close identity	D authored as a short committed advance
4 · The audio cue floor	Six to nine one-shots	Already planned post-M4; cuts nothing promised for Phase 1
5 · Arena dressing	Visual identity	Gray-box floor, walls, doorway axis
6 · Per-fighter timing flavor	Presentation-level identity	Identical values for both — already the recommendation

WHAT IS NEVER CUT

Nothing on that list touches the Final Clash, the meter, the double gate, the first Impact Window, or the win/loss outcomes. Those five are what makes the duel a duel — if they will not fit, the answer is to cut attacks and avatars, not the loop.

DEFINITION OF DONE · LOCKED

AREA	ACCEPTANCE CONDITION
Combat	Real-time controls remain responsive before and after every cinematic beat
Selection	Either avatar enters the same complete shared-framework duel
AI	Crimson Vanguard completes all six states and never strands the encounter
Phase 2	50% escalation changes pressure parameters and presentation, not the attack set
Climax	Final Clash obeys both unlock conditions and supports recovery after failure
Readability	All three fighters remain legible in motion and at combat distance
Scope	One complete duel runs start to finish in Unreal Engine 5.8 on PC

Release plan to 1 September 2026

PHASE	WINDOW	DELIVERABLE
Phase 1 — the playable duel	now → 1 Sept	A duel that can be fought start to finish , with <i>some</i> design on it — not a bare gray-box tech demo. M1 → M4, then a thin presentation floor.
Phase 2 — polish	after Phase 1 plays	As polished as possible — graphics, VFX, camera, sound, arena reaction. Full M5.

How Phase 1 gets a look without breaking milestone order. M5 stays gated behind a stable M4. Phase 1 earns its visual identity by **dressing the proxies**: M1–M4 may stand up free third-party meshes, animations, and set dressing from the start. **Picking a proxy asset is asset selection, not a presentation pass**. What stays M5 is the *tuned* work — hit-stop feel, camera choreography, VFX authoring, sound design, arena impact reaction, final character treatment.

THE CRITICAL PATH IS APPROVALS, NOT CODE

The largest single risk to shipping is not engineering. It is that ~35 researched values are still unapproved, and the build cannot legitimately consume any of them. A developer may create the exposed variable and leave it blank; it cannot be signed off. Every day the approval batch waits, a day of tuning is lost at the far end, where there is no slack.

APPROVE IN THIS ORDER — EACH BATCH UNBLOCKS THE MILESTONE BENEATH IT		
BATCH	ITEMS	UNBLOCKS
1 — today	Q1 · Q4 · Q5 · Q28 · Q6 · Q7 · Q8 · Q14 · Q15 · Q16 · Q11	M1 sign-off — the whole player kit
2 — within 3 days	Q2 (+ item 64 / C3) · Q3 · Q10 · Q12 · Q13 · Q25 · Q18 · Q27 · Q30 · Q24	M2 — the rival, its data table, the arena
3 — within 7 days	Q9 · Q26 · Q29 · C2's HUD gate indicator	M3 — meter, HUD, Impact Windows
4 — within 10 days	Q17 · Q19 · Q20 · Q21 · Q23	M4 — the Final Clash
Anytime	Q31 · items 43, 44, 45	M5 — after the ship date

The fifteen days

Aug 17–21 D–15 → D–11	Finish M1 Light combo (3 sections + finisher), dodge with i-frames, perfect-dodge window, counter and whiff lockout, lock-on. Replace the hardcoded 100 HP with the tuning asset. Grow the arena to the approved footprint. Gate — playable loop with the selected proxy: combo, dodge, perfect dodge, counter, health all live.
Aug 22–25 D–10 → D–7	Finish M2 Complete the existing attack driver into the six named states with visible debug names; add Select Attack by range band; author Attack A from its data row; Attack B <i>only if</i> A's full loop passes; wire the Phase 2 parameter swap on Return to Neutral. Gate — six states cycle without deadlock; returns to Neutral every attempt.
Aug 26–28 D–6 → D–4	Finish M3 Ascension Meter component; HUD meter bar and the C2 gate indicator; the first (0.75 s) and standard Impact Windows; apply V1–V5 — the restore contract is the sign-off condition, not a follow-up. Gate — earned prompt, success <i>and</i> failure branches, control restored, no stranded cinematic state.
Aug 29–30 D–3 → D–2	Finish M4 The double gate; the two Clash beats; success → win screen; failure → the seven-step recovery; loss when player health reaches zero; the simplified selection screen. Gate — a duel that can be fought start to finish, won, and lost.
Aug 31 D–1	Freeze No new systems. Thin presentation floor only: hit-stop on the combo finisher, the existing camera shakes, telegraph emissive. Package, run the acceptance pass, write the submission notes. Gate — build on disk, runs from a cold launch.
Sept 1	Ship Phase 1
Sept 2 →	Phase 2 / M5 Audio cue floor, character treatment, arena reaction, VFX authoring, camera choreography, the editorial selection screen.

The schedule assumes the cut line is available. If M1 is not finished by 21 August or M2 by 25 August, take cut 1 (Attacks C and D) immediately rather than compressing M3 and M4 — those two contain everything that makes the duel readable as a *duel*, and they have the least slack.

FOUR HOUSEKEEPING ITEMS WITH REAL RISK ATTACHED

1. **The Unreal work sits on feature branches, not on `main`.** Fifteen commits of duel work live on a feature branch while `main` carries only the production baseline. Merge deliberately and early — not on 31 August.
2. **The project's default map is still the template level, not the duel graybox.** A package built today launches into the wrong level. One setting, two minutes, and it must not be discovered by a grader.
3. **The attack DataTable pause must be lifted this week** and the user-defined struct created by hand in the editor, or M2 has nothing to read.
4. **Two approvals are open and are the designer's alone:** the countersignature on the Vanguard attack-data approval packet, and the four canon questions about the rival reference sheet. Neither blocks M1 or M2's Attack A.

When the calendar and the wish list disagree, a complete fought duel on 1 September beats a beautiful incomplete one.

Revision log — v0.4 → v1.0

SECTION	CHANGE IN V1.0	TYPE
00	Status key added; every value now carries Locked / Approved / Proposed / Open / Built	NEW
01	High concept, pillars, motivation, and scope lock carried forward verbatim; a paragraph added on what exists in the world since v0.4	Preserved + extended
02	Player combat kit tuning table added (11 rows, all proposed); Impact Window cooldown added; three structural implementation rules recorded	Extended
03	Q22 recorded as approved — the 1 HP floor is permanent and the Final Clash is the only win condition, with constraints C1/C2/C3; Clash execution layer added; the meter re-characterized as an anti-passivity floor rather than a race	REVISED
04	26 per-attack timing values added (in range); bands, cooldowns, damage, travel added; rival scale approved at 208 cm; four implementation findings recorded; rival walk speed named open	Extended
05	Rewritten. Milestone table carries real state; what is built and what is not; four architecture divergences named ; the V1–V5 restore contract recorded as approved and unapplied	REWRITTEN
06	Rewritten around the tooling that actually exists — crew, goal planner, four pipelines — with the no-runtime-LLM boundary reaffirmed and the no-numbers copy rule added	REWRITTEN
07	Scale approved; proxy cast added with the rival proxy recommendation and its missed decision date ; four presentation decisions recorded and placed in M5	Extended
08	Arena footprint added; mezzanine ruled set dressing; asset sourcing, rights, and the audio-in-M5 position stated with its readability cost	Extended
09	Scope lock and definition of done preserved verbatim; release cut line added as a new ordered list requiring approval	Preserved + new
10	Two-phase release plan, approval batches on the critical path, and the fifteen-day schedule	NEW
11–12	This log, and the open decision register	NEW

Nothing in v0.4 was reversed, and nothing in this document supersedes a GDD line. Every value added either fills a blank v0.4 deliberately left open or is drawn from inside a range v0.4 published. The one approved decision, Q22, interprets the scope of a floor the GDD already states.

Open decision register

35 items are proposed and awaiting the designer. 1 is blocked on a human.

Full detail lives in the TODO and the nine dispatch files; this is the register of what actually gates the ship date.

Blocking or overdue

ITEM	QUESTION	WHY IT IS HERE
Q7 BLOCKING	Perfect-dodge window — 0.12 s recommended	Blocking because it changes <i>what the game</i> is, not how it is tuned. Repeatability is unverified: the check proves the pocket's onset is reachable at ~250 ms human reaction time, not that a human can hit 0.12 s repeatably. Playtest protocol: start at 0.15 s and tighten, never the reverse.
Q30 OVERDUE	Rival proxy — Paragon: Crunch	Its own recommendation set a decide-by date of 9 August, which has passed . The import must land before the attack montages are authored ; swapping afterward costs 2.0–3.0 days and is forbidden. The single most time-sensitive open item.
item 64 / C3 OPEN	≤25% rival health and meter 100 do not arrive close together — meter at ~0:40–1:25, the health gate at ~2:53	C3 came from the one decision carrying recorded designer approval, and a dispatch may not amend an approved constraint's success criterion. Two paths: accept meter-first ordering as C3's real intent and amend C3 explicitly on the record, or take Q2 → 1050–1100, which independently also fixes the scrappy-player ~5:24 overshoot past the 3–5 minute target.
item 49 OPEN	Crimson Vanguard's MaxWalkSpeed is unspecified	Under the approved Q22, a rival slower than the player can be kited forever and the duel cannot end . Bounds exist from two directions — lower from the spacing work, upper ≈1030 uu/s from the Clash work — but the value must be set, and the Clash separation cannot be validated until it is.
item 63 APPROVED, UNAPPLIED	V1–V5 have not been applied to the integration plan	M3 does not sign off until they are. M1 and M2 proceed regardless.
item 26 BLOCKED ON A HUMAN	Four canon questions about the rival reference sheet	Correctly unresolved — the transcription disclaims itself, and a low-confidence image description may not settle canon. Attack A is not blocked either way: authored text outranks an image description, and a reference sheet cannot add a mechanic.

Approve to unblock each milestone

MILESTONE	ITEMS AWAITING APPROVAL
M1	Q1 · Q4 · Q5 · Q28 · Q6 · Q7 · Q8 · Q14 · Q15 · Q16 · Q11
M2	Q2 · Q3 · Q10 · Q12 · Q13 · Q25 · Q18 · Q27 · Q24 · Q30 · item 18
M3	Q9 · Q26 · Q29 · item 63 · C2's HUD gate indicator
M4	Q17 · Q19 · Q20 · Q21 · Q23
M5	Q31 · items 43, 44, 45

Known-weak answers — so approval is informed, not blind

ITEM	WEAKNESS
Q8 · 0.55 s whiff lockout	No prior art exists for whiffed-parry recovery frames in any shipped game. Derived purely from the GDD's own ranges. The weakest number in the player kit.
Q12 · attack cooldowns	No shipped game publishes AI attack cooldowns. Derived entirely from the GDD's own state ranges.
Q19 · Clash beat-1 lead	The weakest-sourced answer in the Final Clash group — no shipped game publishes a numeric QTE window.
Q25 / Q12 interaction	Attack A's Phase 1 cycle sits 0.03 s inside its cooldown, producing 10.7 dmg/s at close range. Needs one joint tuning session, not two separate approvals.
Q7	Motor-timing repeatability unverified — out of research budget.

A FINDING THREE RESEARCH GROUPS REPORTED INDEPENDENTLY

No shipped game publishes per-attack boss telegraph durations, recovery durations, AI cooldowns, numeric QTE windows, or knockback distances in world units. Where a number here has no prior art, it says so rather than citing something that does not exist. **These are playtest starting points, not settled values** — which is exactly what v0.4 said they would be.

Document authority and change control

1. **The PDF is the source of truth.** Until this draft is approved and re-issued, GDD v0.4 outranks this document and every other document in the repository.
2. **gdd/ is generated and is never hand-edited.** To change what it says, change the PDF and re-export — sections, page images, and reference-sheet descriptions together.
3. **Approving this draft is a real act.** It promotes every *approved* row to canon, converts each *proposed* row the designer signs into an approved value with a dated entry in the decision record, and deletes the corresponding TODO item. Rows left proposed stay proposed — approving the document does **not** approve them by inclusion.
4. **No agent may promote a value, resolve a provisional number, or fill an open field on its own authority.** It surfaces the question instead. A value left open is a pass.

Central promise. Real-time martial-arts combat rewards player skill with brief, earned anime-style cinematic spectacle.

Ascendant Impact · GDD v1.0 final draft · 17 August 2026 · Unreal Engine 5.8 / PC